



The dark outline around the fossil is a preserved impression of *Darwinius*'s hair, which tells us that it was covered in dense fur.

Delicate fossil

Fossils from the Messel Pit are very delicate and crumble easily when they dry. In order to extract them from the fragile rocks, paleontologists cover them in yellow resin. This secures the fossils in place while the rocks around them are removed.

Long fingers and toes helped *Darwinius* grasp branches.

The shape of *Darwinius*'s teeth suggests that they were adapted for eating fruit and leaves.

PERFECTLY PRESERVED

DARWINIUS

Nicknamed "Ida," this remarkable fossil of an early primate called *Darwinius* caused quite a stir when it was first purchased from a private collector and studied. Originally hailed as the "missing link" in the evolution of humans from monkeys, paleontologists have since questioned this fossil's importance in understanding our own origins. Today, *Darwinius* is considered to be only distantly related to human ancestors. This specimen was found in an area in Germany called the Messel Pit that is famous for its exceptional fossils, including some that still have evidence of soft tissues such as fur. Millions of years ago, the Messel Pit used to be a deep lake that was poor in oxygen. Any animal that fell in sank to the bottom, where it was covered in soft mud and decomposed very slowly. This preserved its features as it turned into a fossil.